Tamil Cuisine

Introduction to Tamil Cuisine

Tamil cuisine is the traditional food of Tamil Nadu, one of the oldest and most diverse regional cuisines in India. It is based on rice, lentils, vegetables, tamarind, coconut, curry leaves and a rich range of spices, and it has both vegetarian and non-vegetarian traditions. The cuisine varies by region, with major styles such as Chettinad, Kongu (Coimbatore and Erode), Madurai, Tirunelveli, Thanjavur and Chennai food. It has been shaped by climate, agriculture, trade and religion, and its use of fermented batters, pulses and millets gives it health benefits. Tamil food is celebrated around the world, and idli, dosa, sambar and filter coffee are famous across India.

Staples and Flavours

Rice is the staple, eaten with sambar (a lentil and vegetable stew with tamarind and spices), rasam (a thin, peppery, tangy soup), kuzhambu (tamarind-based gravies, such as vatha kuzhambu and mor kuzhambu), poriyal (dry stir-fried vegetables with grated coconut), kootu (vegetables cooked with lentils), appalam (papad), vadagam and vathal (sun-dried fritters and vegetables), pickles and curd. The six tastes recognised in Tamil tradition are sweet, sour, salt, bitter, pungent and astringent, and a traditional meal includes all six. Common seasonings are mustard seeds, curry leaves, asafoetida, red chillies, black pepper, cumin, fenugreek and tamarind. Sesame oil, coconut oil and groundnut oil are used for cooking, and ghee is added at the end.

What Is a Traditional Banana-Leaf Meal Called?

A traditional meal served on a banana leaf is called a "saapadu", more fully "vazhai ilai saapadu" (banana-leaf meal), and when it is a grand feast, it is called a virundhu. In Kerala, the equivalent is called a sadya. The banana leaf is used as a natural, hygienic, biodegradable plate and is believed to add a mild flavour to hot food and to have antioxidants. The meal follows a traditional order of serving and eating. Items such as salt, pickle, a sweet, poriyal or kootu, and appalam are served at the top of the leaf, and the rice is placed in the centre, followed by dal with ghee, sambar, then rice with vatha kuzhambu, then rasam, and finally curd rice or buttermilk, with payasam, a sweet pudding, served along the way or at the end. Guests eat with their hands, and the leaf is folded inwards when the meal is over to show satisfaction, and folded outward at funerals. At weddings and festivals such as Pongal and Deepavali, feasts of 20 or more items are served. Many hotels in Tamil Nadu serve "meals" on banana leaves at lunchtime.

What Is Chettinad Cuisine Known For?

Chettinad cuisine comes from the Chettinad region of the Sivaganga district of Tamil Nadu, with Karaikudi as its centre, and was developed by the Nattukottai Chettiar community, a trading community. It is famous for being one of the spiciest and most aromatic cuisines of India, using freshly ground spice masalas with a wide range of spices, including black pepper, red chillies, fennel (saunf), cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, star anise, bay leaf, kalpasi (stone flower or black stone flower), marathi mokku (kapok buds) and anasipoo. Chettinad food is known for its non-vegetarian dishes, such as Chettinad chicken curry, pepper chicken, mutton kola urundai (meatballs), fish curry, and the use of sun-dried meats and salted vegetables, but it also has delicious vegetarian dishes such as kuzhi paniyaram, kavuni arisi (black rice) dessert, paal paniyaram, kandharappam, seedai, adhirasam and the unique sweets and snacks. The Chettiars' grand mansions in towns like Karaikudi, Kanadukathan and Devakottai are also tourist attractions, and Chettinad food is served in restaurants worldwide.

Three South Indian Breakfast Dishes

Three popular South Indian breakfast dishes are idli, dosa and pongal. Idli is a soft steamed cake made from a fermented batter of rice and urad dal, eaten with sambar and chutney. Dosa is a thin crispy pancake made from the same batter, and it comes in many varieties such as masala dosa, ghee roast, paper dosa, onion uttapam and set dosa. Ven pongal is a savoury porridge of rice and moong dal flavoured with pepper, cumin and ghee, served with vadai and sambar. Other breakfast items include vada (medu vada), upma, idiyappam (string hoppers), appam with coconut milk, puttu, kuzhi paniyaram, pesarattu, parotta with salna in Madurai, and kothu parotta. World Idli Day is celebrated on 30 March, an idea started in Chennai in 2015. Fermentation of batter makes idli and dosa easy to digest and rich in vitamin B and probiotics.

Beverages and Sweets

Filter coffee, made by slowly brewing ground coffee with chicory in a metal filter and served with frothy hot milk in a steel tumbler and dabarah, is a symbol of Tamil culture. Other drinks are neer mor (spiced buttermilk), elaneer (tender coconut), nannari sarbath, panagam and jigarthanda of Madurai. Tamil sweets include payasam, Tirunelveli halwa, Srivilliputhur palkova, Kovilpatti kadalai mittai, Madurai's jigarthanda, as well as mysore pak, laddu, kesari, adhirasam and murukku and seedai as snacks.

Regional Specialities

Madurai is known for kari dosa, parotta, jigarthanda and its late-night food culture, Thanjavur for its delta rice dishes, Tirunelveli for halwa, Kongu cuisine for its use of coconut and small onions, with dishes like arisi paruppu sadam and ragi kali, and Chennai for its mix of Tamil, Telugu and other influences, with tiffin items and the filter coffee. Fish and seafood curries are popular in coastal districts such as Nagapattinam, Ramanathapuram and Chennai's Kasimedu. Millets such as ragi, kambu and thinai are used in dishes like koozh, kali and dosa.

Health and Culture

Traditional Tamil food emphasises balance, with spices such as turmeric, pepper, cumin and fenugreek that are valued in Siddha medicine for their digestive and healing properties. Meals are eaten sitting on the floor and with the hands, with a sense of ritual. Hospitality is a strong value: "virundhombal", caring for guests, is highly praised in the Thirukkural.

Challenges and Future

Fast food and processed food are replacing home cooking in cities. At the same time, interest in traditional recipes, millets, organic ingredients, regional food festivals and Tamil restaurants overseas is growing.

Quick Facts

- A traditional banana-leaf meal is called saapadu (vazhai ilai saapadu); a grand feast is a virundhu.
- Chettinad cuisine, from Sivaganga district, is known for its spicy, aromatic masalas and non-vegetarian dishes.
- Three South Indian breakfast dishes are idli, dosa and pongal.
- Sambar, rasam, kuzhambu, kootu and poriyal are standard accompaniments to rice.
- World Idli Day is celebrated on 30 March.